



Partly sunny 74/48 • Tomorrow: T-storm 69/38 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, MARCH 19, 2025 • \$4

Partial halt to fighting in Ukraine takes shape

Putin agrees to a 30-day pause on energy targets after talking with Trump

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM, MARY ILYUSHINA AND CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

Russian President Vladimir Putin agreed Tuesday to halt strikes on Ukrainian energy infrastructure after a lengthy conversation with President Donald Trump, a first step toward easing Russia's war on Ukraine, but he appeared resistant to the fuller ceasefire championed by the U.S. leader and endorsed by Kyiv.

The limited agreement showed the difficulty Trump may have in bringing to a close the war in Ukraine despite a campaign promise to do so in "24 hours." Still, the Kremlin embraced the broader conversation with Trump as a signal that it was being welcomed back into the club of global superpowers despite its years-long campaign to capture neighbors' territory, undermine democratic elections and make common cause with U.S. foes in Beijing, Tehran and Pyongyang.

A top Russian official, Kirill Dmitriev, deemed it "a PERFECT call," capturing the Kremlin's glee at the sharp turnabout in White House attitudes toward Russia after Trump's reorientation of generations of U.S. policy. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Tuesday that he would agree to the limited 30-day halt

SEE PUTIN ON A12

Kursk fighting: N. Korean troops seen as key to Ukraine losses. **A11**



EYAD BABA/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

A Palestinian woman sits atop the rubble of her home, destroyed by an Israeli strike Tuesday, in the Nuseirat refugee camp in central Gaza.

Chief justice rebukes Trump's targeting of judges

BY JUSTIN JOUVENAL, ANN E. MARIMOW, PAUL KANE AND NATALIE ALLISON

President Donald Trump called Tuesday for the impeachment of a federal judge who had ruled against him, prompting the chief justice of the United States to issue a stern statement rejecting the idea and asserting the independence of the judiciary.

The Trump administration has forcefully pushed back against

Impeachment is out of line, he says in defense of independent judiciary

U.S. District Judge James E. Boasberg, who ordered the government not to use a controversial wartime authority to deport alleged Venezuelan gang members while litigation over the matter proceeds.

Impeachment of judges is extremely rare, and it is very unlikely that an effort to remove Boasberg would gain the required majorities in a closely divided Congress. But the White House sees the fight — against a judge appointed to the bench by presidents of both parties — as a winning strategy, part of a years-long effort by Trump to use immigration to his political advantage and cast doubts on the credibility of the courts.

Trump posted on social media that Boasberg, the chief judge of

the U.S. District Court for D.C., was a "Radical Left Lunatic of a Judge," writing: "This judge, like many of the Crooked Judges' I am forced to appear before, should be IMPEACHED!!!"

In response to media requests for comment about Trump's online remarks, Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. issued a rare public statement. "For more than two centuries, it has been established that impeachment is not an appropriate response to disagreement

SEE JUDGES ON A4

Court hits brakes on teardown of USAID

Injunction targets Musk, DOGE amid dispute over separation of powers

BY STEVE THOMPSON

A federal judge in Maryland on Tuesday temporarily blocked billionaire Elon Musk and the U.S. DOGE Service from taking further actions to dismantle the U.S. Agency for International Development and ordered that steps be taken to allow the agency to reoccupy its headquarters inside the Ronald Reagan building in Washington, D.C., should the plaintiffs in a lawsuit challenging Musk's actions win their case.

The judge also ordered DOGE to restore email and other access to thousands of employees who have been cut off from the agency, including those stationed in dangerous areas with their jobs in limbo. He barred DOGE from disclosing USAID employees' personal information outside the agency and said any other action relating to USAID must be made with the "express authorization of a USAID official with legal authority."

The preliminary injunction issued by U.S. District Judge Theodore

SEE DOGE ON A16

Federal workers: Administration moves to reinstate 24,000. **A9**



IMAGE FROM VIDEO/NASA

The SpaceX capsule carrying NASA astronauts Sunita Williams, Barry "Butch" Wilmore and Nick Hague, and Russian cosmonaut Alexander Gorbunov, after Tuesday's flawless splashdown.

Trump ends program tracking abductions of Ukrainian youths

BY JOHN HUDSON

The Trump administration has terminated a U.S.-funded initiative that documents alleged Russian war crimes, including a sensitive database detailing the mass deportation of Ukrainian children to Russia, according to U.S. officials familiar with the directive and documents obtained by The Washington Post.

The move has barred the trans-

Observers fear move has compromised evidence of alleged Russian crimes

mission of evidence to prosecutors pursuing multiple criminal cases, including the International Criminal Court's landmark indictment of Russian President

Vladimir Putin for what it has called the "unlawful transfer" of children from occupied areas of Ukraine, U.S. officials said.

Researchers and experts involved in the initiative, spearheaded by Yale University's Humanitarian Research Lab, were informed last month that the State Department had quietly terminated their contract — one of thousands eliminated at the behest of Trump appointee Peter

Marocco and the U.S. DOGE Service, the budget-slashing arm of tech billionaire Elon Musk.

At that time, the researchers lost access to a trove of information, including satellite imagery and biometric data tracking the identities and locations of as many as 35,000 children from Ukraine.

Most alarming to U.S. lawmakers briefed on the matter is the suspected deletion of the re-

Astronauts back home after 9 months in space

Eight-day mission was marred by glitches, then became mired in politics

BY CHRISTIAN DAVENPORT

The spacecraft carrying NASA astronauts Sunita Williams and Barry "Butch" Wilmore splashed down Tuesday evening off the coast of Florida after a 286-day odyssey that started with a harrowing technical problem that forced NASA to swap vehicles and extend the mission from about eight days to nine months.

Williams and Wilmore flew back to Earth with NASA's Nick Hague and Russian cosmonaut Aleksandr Gorbunov, who together are known as Crew-9, in a SpaceX Dragon capsule.

"Crew-9 going home," Hague said as the capsule undocked

from the International Space Station early Tuesday.

The astronauts settled into the gulf off the coast of Florida under four parachutes in what NASA called "pristine" conditions shortly before 6 p.m. NASA moved up their return date by a day because it said the weather looked good Tuesday evening "ahead of less favorable weather conditions expected later in the week."

The flight home came after Williams and Wilmore, both NASA veterans, orbited Earth more than 4,500 times, traveling more than 120 million miles on the orbiting laboratory at a speed of 17,500 mph, according to NASA.

The safe return marked an end to a saga that started when Williams and Wilmore approached the station June 6 in a test flight of Boeing's Starliner spacecraft. Several of the capsule's thrusters used to orient the vehicle failed to

SEE ASTRONAUTS ON A8

IN THE NEWS

Social Security changes The agency will require millions of Americans who file for benefits by phone to verify their identity online or in person at a field office. **A5**

Communal meal With help from friends and neighbors, a D.C. woman is cooking stew daily in Mount Pleasant and serving it free to all. **B1**

THE NATION **As Arizona prepares** to resume executions, the man who investigated its process objects. **A3** **A tranche** of files on the 1963 JFK assassination was released by the National Archives. **A6**

THE WORLD **Videos offer** a glimpse of Salvadoran prisons and the fate of deportees, rights groups say. **A10** **German lawmakers** passed a spending plan allowing for major investments in defense. **A13**

THE ECONOMY **Small banks**, many in poor areas and red states, could lose funding under a Trump executive order. **A15** **The Trump** administration is set to cut more than 20 percent of the staff members at the taxpayer help branch of the IRS. **A15**

THE REGION **In an unusual** critique, a U.S. district judge objected to the D.C. police chief's public denial that two officers covered up a deadly pursuit. **B1** **An 82-year-old man** in North Carolina was charged in the 1979 killing of a 31-year-old woman in Maryland. **B1**

STYLE **The Oval Office** ivy, which long sat on the room's mantel, recently disappeared. We found out where it went. **C1** **FOOD** **Kimbap**, a customizable Korean staple, is making waves in U.S. grocery chains and across media platforms. **E1**

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